FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

FUN VS WINNING PRESSURE

Is your child's team built for growing, or just for winning?

THE QUICK VERSION

> Winning is fun, and wanting to win is completely healthy. But for young players, the best environments put skill-building, teamwork and enjoyment first, and the wins tend to follow. Here's how to tell the difference when you're standing on the sideline.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

When the scoreboard becomes the main focus, the best few kids play most of the minutes, mistakes get punished and players get locked into one position too early. Kids learn less, enjoy it less and are more likely to drop out. A development-first environment gives every player the chance to grow.

SPOT THE DIFFERENCE

DEVELOPMENT FIRST

- ✓ Fair game time shared across the squad
- ✓ Coaches teach and encourage after mistakes
- ✓ Players try different positions
- ✓ Sessions full of touches, games and fun
- ✓ Calm, positive sideline

SCOREBOARD FIRST

- × The best kids play, the rest sit
- × Yelling or punishment after mistakes
- × Kids locked into one position early
- × Long lines, laps and punishment running
- × Adults shouting at referees and players

GOOD QUESTIONS TO ASK THE CLUB

01
How is game time shared?

02
What does a typical training session look like?

03
How do coaches respond to mistakes?

04
What is the club's development philosophy?

TRY THIS

1. **Watch a training session**
   Games show you the result. Training shows you the environment.
2. **Ask your child directly**
   “Do you feel like you’re getting better? Do you look forward to training?”
3. **Be the calm voice**
   Cheer good play from both teams. Your child takes their cue from you.
4. **Speak up kindly**
   If the pressure feels too high, have a calm chat with the coach or club.
5. **It’s okay to move on**
   If nothing changes, finding a better-fit environment is a smart move, not a failure.

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
“Did you learn anything new today?”	~~“You need to win this one.”~~
“Have fun out there!”	~~“Don’t mess it up.”~~
“Great pass, number 7! (even the other team’s)”	~~“Ref, are you blind?!”~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] My child gets fair game time and enjoys training
- [ ] I’ve watched at least one training session
- [ ] I cheer more than I instruct from the sideline
- [ ] I know what the club values for junior players

Can’t tick them all yet? That’s normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH’S CORNER

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Junior premierships are forgotten fast. The touch on the ball, the confidence and the friendships are what carry a player forward.

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM